

Symbiosis of Power: How Colonial History and Post-Independence Strategies Sustained Malaysia's Electoral Authoritarianism

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Malaysia's electoral system, dominated for six decades by the United Malays National Organization (UMNO), exemplifies a paradox: a regime that holds regular elections yet systematically undermines political pluralism. This paper examines the roots of Malaysia's electoral authoritarianism—a system marked by gerrymandering, media censorship, and repression under laws—to answer a critical question: Are these limitations the product of historical colonial legacies, post-independence authoritarian strategies, or an interplay of both? I argue that Malaysia's hybrid regime stems from symbiosis between historical and proximate factors. Colonial rule entrenched ethnic stratification and centralized institutions, which UMNO weaponized post-independence through institutional manipulation, Islamization, and patronage. However, proximate crises like the 1MDB scandal exposed systemic fragility, catalyzing the 2018 electoral upset. By analyzing this interplay, the paper demonstrates that authoritarian resilience in Malaysia is neither path-dependent nor crisis-driven but an intricate product of historical frameworks enabling modern elite strategies.

Malaysia's electoral authoritarianism cannot be divorced from its colonial past. British rule (1824–1957) entrenched two interlocking systems that continue to shape politics: ethnic stratification and centralized authoritarian institutions. The colonial state's use of censuses, maps, and occupational segregation rigidly categorized Malaysia's population into ethnic silos. As Benedict Anderson argues¹, colonial censuses were not neutral tools but “institutions of power” that fabricated social categories to legitimize domination, constructing racial identities like “Malay” “Chinese”, “Indian” as administrative categories rather than organic groupings. These divisions were reinforced by economic policies that assigned ethnic groups to specific roles: Chinese laborers in tin mines, Indians on rubber plantations, and Malays in subsistence agriculture². This “plural society” model, as John Furnivall coins it³, institutionalized economic inequality along ethnic lines, with Malays lagging behind Chinese and Indian communities in wealth and education by independence⁴. These divisions were also politicized post-independence, as seen in the 1946 Malayan Union crisis. In a context of enduring economic disparities with three quarters of Malaysians living below the poverty line being Malay until the 1960s⁵, The British proposal to grant citizenship to Chinese migrants threatened to irreversibly upset the fragile ethnic balance. Sparking mass protests and the formation of UMNO to protect Malay privileges cement a colonial legacy of ethnic competition.

The 1969 racial riots—triggered by Chinese electoral gains and Malay marginalization—marked a turning point. Colonial rule also bequeathed centralized institutions designed to suppress

¹ Benedict Anderson (1991: 167)

² Sutherland (2018: 43)

³ Furnivall (1948: 307)

⁴ Kuhonta (2011: 81)

⁵ Id (2011: 81)

dissent. UMNO responded by tightening its grip through institutional reforms and co-optation. First, the New Economic Policy (NEP) redistributed wealth to Malays via quotas in education, employment, and corporate equity, enforced by a bureaucratic machinery (National Planning Council, Economic Planning Unit) that synergized UMNO's agenda with state power⁶. Second, UMNO absorbed opposition parties into the Barisan Nasional (BN) coalition, creating an "iron cage" where dissent was managed behind closed doors⁷. Third, UMNO inherited and expanded colonial-era emergency powers, such as the Internal Security Act (ISA), which allowed arbitrary detention without trial⁸. Inherited from British emergency laws, these tools were repurposed by UMNO into an authoritarian toolkit setting the stage for its dominance. While colonial legacies provided UMNO with the institutional and ideological scaffolding blending ethnic patronage with coercive state power, post-independence leaders like Mahathir Mohamad weaponized these structures to personalize power and suppress dissent.

UMNO's authoritarianism evolved under Mahathir Mohamad (1981–2003), who combined colonial-era institutions with new tactics to centralize power. However, elite fragmentation—exemplified by the 1MDB scandal—ultimately eroded UMNO's dominance, illustrating how proximate crises interact with historical weaknesses.

Under Mahathir Mohamad (1981–2003), UMNO perfected institutional weaponization to personalize power. Mahathir's tactics—packing, rigging, and circumventing—transformed Malaysia into a personalized regime, demonstrating how proximate leadership choices can amplify historical authoritarian legacies. First, Mahathir engaged in packing key institutions with loyalists

⁶ Kuhonta (2011: 96–97)

⁷ Id (2011: 88)

⁸ Slater (2003: 83)

to neutralize rivals like the 1987 UMNO leadership crisis, where Tengku Razaleigh nearly unseated him⁹. This ensured that institutions like the courts and police became tools of executive repression, epitomized by the 1998 police beating of Anwar Ibrahim, whose detention under the Internal Security Act (ISA) showcased the regime's brutality¹⁰. He then "rigged" UMNO's constitution, requiring challengers to secure nominations from 30% of party branches, effectively stifling internal democracy¹¹. Third, he circumvented formal governance channels during crises. When the 1997 Asian Financial Crisis threatened his allies, Mahathir sidelined Finance Minister Anwar Ibrahim by creating the National Economic Action Council (NEAC), diverting funds from state assets like Petronas to bail out loyalists¹². These tactics institutionalized personalist rule while maintaining a facade of democratic process.

UMNO further entrenched its rule through state-led Islamization, competing with the Islamist PAS party for Malay support. Mahathir promoted Islamic banking and universities while banning minority sects like Shi'ism, institutionalizing Sunni orthodoxy as a pillar of Malay identity^{13,14}. Repression of religious minorities peaked during elections, such as the 1996 federal ban on Shi'a practices, to galvanize UMNO's rural base¹⁵. This fusion of ethnic and religious nationalism allowed UMNO to position itself as the defender of Malay-Muslim interests, marginalizing secular and non-Malay opposition.

UMNO's decline began with elite fragmentation under Najib Razak (2009–2018). The 1MDB scandal—where \$4.5 billion was embezzled from a state fund—exposed systemic

⁹ Slater (2003: 89)

¹⁰ Id (2003: 95)

¹¹ Id (2003: 90)

¹² Id (2003: 92)

¹³ Jung (2018: 137)

¹⁴ Musa (2022: 26)

¹⁵ Id (2022: 31)

corruption and alienated UMNO's rural Malay base¹⁶. While patronage had long sustained UMNO, the scale of Najib's greed, coupled with rising living costs, turned Malays against the party. Mahathir capitalized on this weakness by forming Pakatan Harapan (PH), a coalition of ideologically opposed parties united by anti-Najib sentiment. His personal credibility as a former UMNO leader swayed rural Malays: one voter declared, "Yes, we love BN, but we love Mahathir more"¹⁷. The 2018 election—which ousted BN—highlighted UMNO's dependence on both historical ethnic patronage and proximate legitimacy. The interplay between colonial legacies and proximate factors explains why UMNO's authoritarianism persisted for decades but collapsed under elite-driven crises.

Malaysia's electoral authoritarianism cannot be reduced to either history or contemporary politics; it is the product of their symbiosis. Colonial frameworks provided UMNO with tools to suppress dissent, while post-independence leaders adapted these structures to modern challenges.

The Internal Security Act (ISA), inherited from British emergency laws and wielded by Mahathir to detain critics like Anwar Ibrahim, demonstrates how colonial "emergency-style powers" were repurposed for regime survival¹⁸. Similarly, UMNO's Bumiputera policies—reserving economic privileges for Malays—echoed colonial ethnic hierarchies, ensuring loyalty through material benefits¹⁹. These policies were framed as "correcting" colonial inequities but perpetuated dependency on UMNO's patronage. On the other hand, UMNO's survival also relied

¹⁶ Abdullah (2018: 526)

¹⁷ Id (2018: 528)

¹⁸ Slater (2003: 83)

¹⁹ Kuhonta (2011: 90)

on adapting colonial tools to new contexts. For example, Mahathir co-opted Islamist rhetoric to counter PAS, promoting Islamic banking and universities to legitimize UMNO as a “modern” Muslim party²⁰. Electorally, gerrymandering—rooted in colonial spatial control via maps²¹—ensured BN’s dominance by overweighting rural Malay constituencies²².

Mahathir’s coalition-building exploited UMNO’s internal decay. Senior UMNO figures, including Deputy Prime Minister Muhyiddin Yassin, defected to PH, framing Najib’s corruption as a betrayal of Malay interests (Abdullah 2018: 530). This elite fragmentation mirrored earlier splits, such as the 1987 UMNO crisis, but with a critical difference: the 1MDB scandal alienated UMNO’s rural base, depriving it of its traditional electoral shield (Abdullah 2018: 529). PH’s victory, however, did not signify democratization. Instead, it reflected a “regime split” (Abdullah 2018: 532), where UMNO’s failure to manage elite rivalries and corruption allowed a personalized opposition coalition to temporarily prevail.

Finally, authoritarian institutions persisted post-2018. Gerrymandered districts, restrictive media laws, and the ISA—though less frequently used—remained intact, illustrating the durability of colonial and UMNO-era frameworks²³. The PH government, dependent on Mahathir’s autocratic credibility, failed to dismantle these structures, underscoring how historical legacies constrain even reformist coalitions²⁴.

²⁰ Jung (2018: 137)

²¹ Anderson (1991: 248)

²² Arugay & Sinpeng (2018: 103)

²³ Arugay & Sinpeng (2018: 103)

²⁴ Beech & Paddock (2018)

To conclude, Malaysia's electoral authoritarianism reveals the enduring interplay of colonial legacies and post-independence agency. British rule entrenched ethnic hierarchies and coercive institutions, which UMNO repurposed to consolidate power through patronage, repression, and Islamization. Yet proximate factors—Mahathir's personalization of power and Najib's 1MDB corruption—exposed the fragility of these systems, enabling the 2018 regime shift. While this election marked a rupture, it did not dismantle colonial-era frameworks like gerrymandering or ethnoreligious nationalism, underscoring how deeply historical inequities constrain democratic change. Malaysia's case illustrates that authoritarian resilience hinges not on history or modern crises alone, but on their dynamic symbiosis—a lesson critical to understanding hybrid regimes globally.

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